GERMAN U-BOAT CREW

When they were at the peak of their effectiveness, between 1941 and 1943, Germany's U-boats came close to cutting Britain's supply lifeline across the Atlantic. Commanded by captains of an independent, buccaneering spirit, they hunted across vast expanses of ocean, assembling in "wolf packs" to savage merchant convoys. In total, U-boats sank some 14 million tons of Allied shipping in the course of the war. Yet the U-boats were themselves the prey of Allied hunters, in the shape of escort warships and patrol aircraft. U-boat crews suffered probably the highest percentage casualties of any group of combatants in World War II. Some 1,000 U-boats were sunk and roughly two out of every three U-boat crewmen who served in the war lost their lives.

U-boat crews entered the war as a highly trained elite. Admiral Karl Dönitz, who masterminded the U-boat programme, insisted that his men had five years training before they went operational, thus instilling a high degree of professionalism and team spirit. The Type VII, the most common U-boat, was crewed by four officers and 40 petty officers and seamen. Some crew members had their own specialities – for example, the personnel who maintained and fired the torpedoes or the radio staff with their Enigma encoding machine. Others performed general duties, such as standing watch or operating the guns.

ON PATROL

The routines of a patrol in the Atlantic were tough and demanding. The U-boat travelled on the surface – submerging was an emergency tactic only. Constant alertness was required to avoid being surprised by enemy aircraft or warships. Watch was kept 24 hours a day by four seamen, each surveying 90 degrees of the horizon, and a watch officer in the conning (or observation) tower. A four-hour watch could be a severe trial in bad weather, as freezing waves swept over the men on the rolling deck. Inside, conditions were cramped and claustrophobic. Some men shared bunks on a shift system. Only the captain had a curtain to give some privacy to his living space. On a patrol that would last weeks or even months, the crew were unable to bath or shave or change their clothes. Deodorant was issued to palliate the effects of enforced uncleanliness in a confined space.

> "A GIANT'S FIST SHOOK THE BOAT. IT SOUNDED LIKE THE DISSOLUTION OF THE UNIVERSE. I WAS CHOKING, THINKING IT WAS THE END."
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> **WOLFGANG HIRSCHFELD** DESCRIBING A DEPTH-CHARGE ATTACK ON U-109 BY AN AMERICAN DESTROYER IN 1942

Returning to base
A German U-boat arrives at its base in Kiel in November 1939. Most of the crew are on deck, wearing their leather weather-protection gear.

